Expected to Stay, Choosing to Go

Navigating family and cultural expectations.

A FIELD GUIDE FOR MAKING A DIFFERENT CHOICE

01 The condition

Some families have plans for you that were never spoken, because they never needed to be. Where you would live. What you would study. Who would look after whom, and when.

The plans were rarely hostile. They were assumed, the way weather is assumed. So choosing differently can feel like breaking something, even when nothing has been broken.

Before the conversation comes a quieter piece of work: telling apart the parts of a decision that are yours from the parts you inherited. Both can be held with care. Only one of them is yours to decide.

02 How to use this sample

Write the decision at the top of the next page. Break it into its parts, and sort each one without arguing with yourself. Use the script only when the sorting feels finished.

03 Whose is it?

The decision _____

PART OF THE DECISION	MINE	INHERITED	NOT SURE
	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐

If no one were going to be disappointed, what would I choose?

WHEN YOU ARE READY TO SAY IT

"I've made a decision about [what], and I wanted you to hear it from me. I know it isn't what you pictured. I'm not asking you to agree right away. I'm asking you to stay in the conversation."

Guilt may stay after the decision is made. That is not proof the decision is wrong.

THE FULL FIELD GUIDE

This is a two-page sample of *Expected to Stay, Choosing to Go*, a 18-page field guide. The full version also holds:

— Separating inherited expectations from your own
— Scripts for parents, elders and siblings
— Holidays, visits, and the guilt that doesn't leave on schedule

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